

Nothing Happens After Eleven - RUN

Compiled table document. Source files
(ADVENTURE.md, plot.md,
locations.md, encounters.md,

secrets.md, characters.md, npcs/)
remain authoritative. Rebuild this file
when reviewed prep changes. This is
preparation, not session history.

Runtime header

Field	Value
System	SWADE Fifth Printing (2023)
Rank	Novice
Players	1
PC mode	player-supplied (Lilly Dawson)
Active setting modules	none
Supernatural level	none — deliberate for this night; see GM secrets
Historical accuracy	cinematic late-spring 1986 small-town policing; fictional Ashgrove, Oregon; working table date Saturday 17 May 1986
House rules	HR-NFA-001, HR-NFA-002
Expected runtime	3–5 hours (3–4 hour core identified)
Compilation date	2026-09-21
Verified by	Co-GM source review; QUALITY 110/120; Coherence (prep) passed with logic summary; Grounding audit passed (35/35)

Not a scene script. Jump to the situation on the table: SP1 Night Line — the fold, the Main Street steer, and a telephone only Lilly can answer; SP2 Owl Overflow — optional, Daisy's packed counter and a watchman who is not in it; SP3 Mill Camp Road — a dark row that is not weather and not kids; SP4 Fence Line and Earl's Nest — the reversal at the last safe ground; SP5 The Load-Out — climax at the lit deck, four Extras, a truck on a clock, and Len behind a kiln door; SP6 Paper After — the fold callback and a morning that praises her. Payload lives in the named story point or lookup. First 15 minutes and Climax situation are indexes only.

Table terms

Term	Means
The fold	Whitley's habit of folding a complaint heading-down and creasing it once with the side of his hand so its subject disappears before it reaches a basket. A tell, not a signal to anyone else.
Contact states	Three branches set by dispatch, not by prep: dispatched, Kevin alone; dispatched, Lilly with him or already at the fence; no dispatch . Whether Kevin goes in alone decides whether the 00:52 shots fire.
Go-clock	Roy Meeks's departure timer. From the moment he knows police are on his ground — a cruiser at the gate, a light, a shout, a shot — he needs roughly fifteen to twenty minutes to rope the load, kill the light, and pull the flatbed out the spur gate, no later than 01:45. Contact earlier means an earlier departure; 01:10 is only what the arithmetic produces if contact happens at 00:52.
Suspicion floor	The one piece of the night's revelation that is not a discoverable clue: the steer at 18:10, the revealed months-long load-out, and the controlled dawn praise. It lands in every branch, including the ones where nothing is rolled and nothing is heard.
NOT FILEABLE TONIGHT	A GM-only tag on graft evidence: real and reachable, but not a ledger, a signed statement, cash in hand, a confession, or a chain-of-command packet. Night 3 does not take Whitley off the force; night 4 (ashgrove-puzzle-1986) owns proof and the unfair walk.

Notation

Rule	This adventure
First NPC / named creature mention	ALL-CAPS on first mention in each situation, then title case
Trait tests	Notice (–2), Persuasion, Common Knowledge; no invented skills
Information rolls	Fail, success, and raise are always stated
Quoted speech	Table cues in Spoken lines ; not a script
GM Note	Secret or ruling; never player-facing
Optional material	Labeled Optional; never gates the main objective
PC-specific hooks	Labeled PC hook — Lilly; never the only vector
Wild Card / Extra	Every prepared opponent block is labeled. No opposing Wild Card appears on this yard (intentional for a Novice solo)
Handouts	None prepared for this night; no Handouts index below

Opening mood

An ordinary Saturday evening shift closes around a small, defensible act of chief's business: a complaint folded away before its heading is read, an errand nobody wants handed to the newest detective. Nothing about it looks like a decision yet. Hours pass in paperwork and a packed diner three doors from a shuttered pub, and then a telephone rings in an empty

building because the one person left in it happens to be Lilly. What is actually happening eighty yards behind a mill fence — a professional load-out, months old, with old powder moving toward a truck — has nothing to do with her chief's arrangement in the players' eyes yet. It will, but only for her, and only as certainty she can carry and never file.

First 15 minutes

- [] **Play:** Story Point 1 — Night Line (Phase A).
- [] **Handed:** her own paperwork, badge, service pistol, flashlight, notebook, the day car (car 3), and a

Kevlar vest if she takes the minute to put one on before the night gets long.

- [] **Where they are:** the Ashgrove precinct, start of the evening shift, about 18:10, Saturday 17 May 1986.
- [] **Trouble already in motion:** Chief Whitley is folding Friday's mill-noise complaint heading-down in front of her and handing her the Daisy's overflow on Main Street instead — compliance, keep it civil, nothing that needs a detective. That fold and that steer are themselves the opening trouble; hours later (compress the quiet paperwork and, if she goes, the packed diner), the night line rings at 00:20: Rita Holm, West End, her lights and her neighbours' gone with no storm in it.
- [] **First decision:** what to do with a power-loss call that only she can answer — hand it to patrol and keep the Main Street errand, ride with Kevin, roll alone, or spend minutes waking Sgt. Doyle first.
- [] **Which story points to open:** SP1 is essential and opens play. SP2 opens if she takes the Main Street errand seriously or if nobody was ever dispatched. SP3 and SP4 open the moment she drives west.
- [] **If this block overruns:** skip the office color and begin at 00:20 with the phone already ringing; play the fold as something Doyle or the paper basket confirms later.

Mission in 30 seconds

- **Premise:** After Whitley steers Lilly onto Main Street, a 00:20 West End power-loss call pulls her and Kevin to the Cinder Creek yard, where she must stop a salvage load-out, account for Len Pell, and write a scene that can be written.
- **Player objective:** Stop the load-out, account for Len Pell, and bring the night home as a scene that survives a morning's reading.
- **GM intent:** The arc's action night — shots, a live clock, a yard she has to walk into — weighted toward pressure and movement, not evidence work. Underneath it, let her discover her chief's habit the way a working cop would, and end the night certain and unable to prove it.
- **Immediate stakes:** Kevin's safety if he is dispatched alone, Len's clock, the powder's location, and how much of the crew is left to talk tomorrow.
- **Starting decision:** what does she do with a call that is not weather, not kids, and hers alone to answer?

Current situation

Phase A — table start, about 18:10, Whitley's office. WHITLEY catches Lilly at the start of the evening shift holding a Citizen Complaint sheet Nancy typed at 4:05 p.m. Friday: complainant Rita Holm, No. 4 Mill Camp Road, reporting trucks and engine noise at the mill yard late at night. He pencils Ref. patrol — Voss on it, folds it so the heading disappears, and hands her the Daisy's overflow instead — the Owl is shut for Oscar Lind's send-off supper, the whole mill crowd is eating three doors west, keep it civil. He is in his car by 18:25; the folded sheet is in the PATROL — READ basket on the radio-room shelf. Nothing has happened yet at the mill that the town or the precinct knows about.

Phase B — after the jump, 00:20, the radio room. By midnight the building holds only Lilly: Whitley is home, Doyle is home, Nancy went home at five, and Kevin Alder is in car 2 on 328 near Lowater. Rita Holm telephones the night line. Behind the Cinder Creek fence, unseen by anyone in town, the crew is already loading, Len Pell is already behind kiln No. 2, and the powder is already on its clock — none of that has been announced to the table yet; it is what SP3–SP5 reveal. Nothing before Phase B has happened as a scripted certainty; if the player walks Main Street early or never sits at her desk at all, the night still reaches her at 00:20 through the same call, or later through Gil Sorenson, Daisy's, or her own return to the radio room.

Pacing dashboard

Runtime point	Expected position	Optional cut if behind
Opening, first 10–15 min	The fold, the steer, and the 00:20 call answered or missed (SP1)	Skip straight to the phone ringing
30–90 min	Investigation and dispatch decisions active (SP1/SP2/SP3)	Narrate Daisy's instead of playing it; merge West End into the approach
90–150 min	The reversal at the fence (SP4)	Fold Earl's nest into the same beat as the fence read
Final 60–90 min	The yard (SP5)	Keep the magazine as a hazard players smell, not a timed second problem
Final 15–25 min	Paper After (SP6)	Resolve the morning in one scene instead of a precinct round

FIVE-BEAT DASHBOARD

Beat	Story point(s)	Table cue
Explosive opening	SP1	The fold and the steer, then a phone only she can answer at 00:20.
Investigation and meaningful choices	SP1, SP2, SP3	What to do with a power-loss call; a packed diner and a missing watchman; a dark row with no storm behind it.
Escalation or reversal	SP4 (opens onto SP5)	Work light, diesel, and a winch inside a mill that has been closed since 1984 — this is an organized load-out, and there is old powder in it.
Climactic set piece	SP5	Four Extras, a flatbed on the spur, Len behind a kiln door, six cases of old powder on a clock.
Consequences and closure	SP6	A salvage file that can be signed, the fold callback, and a chief who praises her in front of the day shift.

3–4 hour core: Precinct (SP1), a compressed approach that merges West End into the fence line (fold SP3 into SP4's opening beats), the yard (SP5),

and Paper After (SP6). SP2 (Daisy's), waking Doyle, and the magazine as an active timed clock are the material that expands the core to five hours.

Climax situation

- **Location:** the Cinder Creek yard under the stacks, delivered in Story Point 5.
- **Opposition (Wild Cards / Extras):** Roy Meeks, Ned Colfax, Dale Runkle, Jimmy Sloat — four Extras, no opposing Wild Card. Complete profiles live in SP5.
- **Environment and interactive features:** a dark wet lot with stacks, drying sheds, dry kilns, a rail spur and loading deck, a mill office and gate, a scale house, a mill pond, and an inland track to a powder magazine — full geography and illumination/cover tables live in SP4 and SP5.
- **Urgency / countdown:** Meeks's go-clock, running from first police contact to wheels-up in fifteen to twenty minutes, hard ceiling 01:45; the powder's own clock moving it from bunker to pickup to flatbed between about 00:45 and 01:10; Len's clock, conscious until about 01:05 and past the Golden Hour by 01:02.
- **Secondary objective besides defeating everyone:** find Len alive, keep the powder off the truck and off ORE. 328, take the crew rather than scatter it, and leave a scene that survives a morning's reading.
- **Situation payload:** speech, the four Extra profiles plus Len and Kevin, illumination/cover tables, and the powder ruling all live in Story Point 5 (and SP4 for the fence approach).
- **Boundary note:** this index adds no secret payload beyond what SP5 holds; no result here may produce a name above Roy Meeks (`secrets.md`, GM-only boundary).
- **If time is short:** merge the fence read (SP4) directly into arrival at the deck; keep the magazine as background hazard rather than a timed pickup-truck problem; do not manufacture a firefight if the crew would rather leave.

SP 1 Night Line**MOOD — READ THE ROOM**

Mood (table): Floor wax and cold coffee fill a building built for three times the people in it; most of the lights are off, and the radio room's are not. A wire basket of patrol paper sits on the shelf beside a black telephone and a base set humming against 1958 cabinetry, while rain works at the windows of a lot of empty offices. Whitley's hand moves once down a crease in a sheet of paper he is talking past, and then, hours later, in a building that holds nobody but her, that same telephone rings.

- **Goal:** put the chief's habit in front of the player as ordinary office behavior, hand her a job she does not want, and then ring a phone she is the only person who can answer.
- **Situation now:** Phase A, about 18:10: WHITLEY catches Lilly holding Nancy's Citizen Complaint sheet — **Rita Holm, No. 4 Mill Camp Road**, dated 16 May 1986, reporting trucks and engine noise at the mill yard "three or four nights a month."

He pencils Ref. patrol — Voss, folds the sheet so the heading disappears, runs the side of his hand down the crease once while talking about something else, and hands her the Daisy's overflow on Main instead. He drops the folded sheet in the PATROL — READ basket at 18:25 and drives home; he does not leave the house again tonight. Phase B, 00:20: by midnight the building holds only Lilly. Earl Voss cleared West End at 23:10 and has not answered since; Kevin Alder is in car 2 on 328 near Lowater. The night line rings two feet from the basket.

- **Spoken lines (Whitley):** *"Kids, or it's Voss's. Either way it isn't detective work." "Half that pub is going to be in Daisy's tonight. Stand where they can see you and keep it civil."*
- **Spoken lines (Rita Holm, on the night line):** *"It's not the fuses. I did the fuses. It's the whole row and the mill both."* If Lilly keeps her talking: *"I called Friday about the trucks. Nobody came about that either."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Notice while Whitley handles the complaint	She registers that he shrank something and cannot say what. The sheet still ends up in the patrol basket where she can read it any time tonight.	She sees the fold and the single crease and could describe the habit to another cop.	She reads the heading before it disappears: Citizen Complaint, 16 May 1986, Rita Holm, No. 4 Mill Camp Road, trucks at the mill at night.
Common Knowledge on the errand	It looks like a chief giving his newest detective a nothing job, which it also is.	She knows the Owl is shut for Oscar Lind's send-off supper, so the mill crowd is not where it normally is on a Saturday.	She also knows Saturday and Wednesday are the drinking nights — which means Saturday is a night nobody walks the Cinder Creek yard, and the whole town could have told her that.
Notice on the telephone call	She takes the name, the address, and the complaint.	She hears that Rita already checked her own fuse box and her neighbour's porch before she picked up the phone.	Rita volunteers that she telephoned on Friday about trucks at the mill and nobody came — giving Lilly the complaint before she has read the folded sheet.

- **Pressure/escalation:** every minute spent here is a minute Kevin spends arriving alone if he is dispatched. If nobody answers the phone — she is already on Main, or she walks out — Rita rings again at 00:41, then sends her neighbour **Gil Sorenson** of No. 6 into town, and Kevin reaches the mill camp

on his ordinary loop at about 01:20 instead of 00:35.

- **Essential information and vectors:** a power-loss call in the mill camp at 00:20 with no weather behind it; Earl Voss is posted to West End and is not answering; Kevin Alder is in the car and will come if asked; Lilly is the only person in the building.

Independent vectors: Rita Holm on the line; the folded complaint in the PATROL – READ basket; Nancy Iverson's carbon of the same complaint in the Friday day file; the duty board showing Voss on West End and Alder on 328 east; the radio itself.

- **Failure changes:** missing the fold costs her nothing tonight — the sheet and its carbon both survive to SP6. Handing the call to patrol and keeping the Main Street errand is a legitimate choice, not a trap; it moves the night into SP2 and puts Kevin at the fence alone if he is raised.
- **Reachable next points:** SP3 if she rolls west; SP4 if she rolls west with or behind Kevin; SP2 if she keeps the Main Street job; SP6 for the sheet in the basket at any hour.

- **Optional / PC hook:** none required here.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: the fold is a habit, not a signal to anyone. Whitley refers the complaint to patrol because that is genuinely defensible and because it keeps the lot off his detective's desk. He does not telephone anybody tonight, before or after Lilly calls him — see `secrets.md`, NHE-01.

On the radio: the base set carries ordinary evening traffic under KCRK 102.3 FM's period-correct rotation; nothing broadcast tonight is evidence and no cue points at the yard.

§ AT-HAND RULES

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), ordinary Trait resolution. HR-NFA-002 Hitting the Books (Research) is available later for the dead-paper rooms; it is not needed here. Quick reminder: nothing in this room is a threat tonight — the precinct carries no lethal risk. Applied here: a failed Notice or Common Knowledge roll here never blocks the night; the folded sheet, Nancy's carbon, and Rita's call are all independently reachable later.

SP 2 Owl Overflow (Daisy's)

Optional. The parallel route, and the vector that reaches Lilly if she never touches the radio. Skippable without blocking anything; the likeliest cut if the table is running short.

MOOD — READ THE ROOM

Mood (table): *Every booth is full and half the room is standing, coats over chair backs, the air thick with fryer smoke and wet wool. Thirty mill people who came out for beer and got a diner are making the best of it, loud and good-humoured, and the counter radio has already lost. Through the west windows Main Street is lit all the way to the fuel canopy, and past that there is nothing at all.*

- **Goal:** give the assigned errand real content, and make sure the night still reaches her if she sat on the radio.
- **Situation now:** reachable any time after about 19:30, and specifically if Lilly took the Main Street

assignment, handed the 00:20 call to patrol, or left the building before it rang. The Owl has been shut to walk-ins since about 18:30 for Oscar Lind's send-off supper. **DAISY PELL** is working the counter alone and has been half-watching her door for a man who has not come through it. Nobody in the room has connected the crowded diner to the dark row west of the creek.

- **Spoken lines (Daisy):** *"Half that pub is sitting in my booths and Len isn't one of them."* If pressed about the key: *"He won't take that key into a bar. Never has. If he's not drinking he's out there."*
- **Spoken lines (Gil Sorenson, only if it reaches about 01:00 with the call unworked):** *"Rita's been on the phone to you people twice. Whole row's black and there's a light up in the mill."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Persuasion with Daisy across a full counter	She is slammed and gives one sentence: the Owl is shut and half of it is in her booths.	She says Len is not among them, on a night he would be, and that she has been half-watching the door for him.	She adds that he will not carry the Rennick key into a bar, so if he is not drinking he is on the lot — and that his truck went west past her window at about half past nine.
Notice from inside the diner	Noise, wet coats, and a crowd.	West along 328 the mill-camp porch lights are out while Main Street and West End Fuel are lit — whatever this is, it is not the town.	She can put a time on it: the row went dark while she was standing there, a little after ten past twelve.
Common Knowledge on the room	Thirty faces and no use.	EARL VOSS is not here and has not been; KEVIN ALDER came through for coffee at about 23:20.	Lind's supper was booked in April and anyone who actually drinks at the Owl has known for weeks that tonight was not a drinking night — which the men working the yard plainly did not.

- **Pressure/escalation: 00:52 pops only if Kevin was dispatched and went in alone** — a short string of flat pops carries across Cinder Creek, and the west end of the diner argues about whether it was a truck. If Lilly rolled with him, or if nobody ever raised him, there is nothing to hear at 00:52 and the room stays loud; Gil Sorenson at about 01:00 is then a vector, not gunfire. At 01:15 the supper breaks up and the Owl empties onto Main either way. Do not fire the 00:52 beat to force her west.
- **Essential information and vectors:** Len Pell is not with the crowd on a night he would be; the Owl was shut, so his routine broke; the mill camp is dark while the town is lit. Independent vectors: Daisy Pell; the dark row visible west along 328; Gil Sorenson at about 01:00; the Owl emptying onto Main at 01:15 with **PAT CALHOUN** in the doorway.

- **Failure changes:** time. Every vector here is repeated elsewhere; staying for all of it costs Len position and costs Kevin cover.
- **Reachable next points:** SP3 or SP4 west across the creek; SP1's radio room if she goes back for the car and the sheet.
- **Optional / PC hook:** none required.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: Daisy's interest is family, not evidence, and she has no idea anything is being taken. No envelope passes in the Owl tonight; Marnie Quade is running a private supper and would not do it in front of thirty people. If Lilly walks into the Owl she finds a retirement dinner (`locations.md`, Daisy's).

On the radio: the diner counter radio, losing to the room — period rotation only; no cue points at the yard.

§ AT-HAND RULES

Authority: core Persuasion and Notice; HR-NFA-002 Patter if she wants Daisy aside from a full counter. Quick reminder: ordinary conversation needs no roll unless the outcome is uncertain and consequential; a failed Patter costs minutes in the middle of the night, not the vector. Applied here: nothing in this diner is a threat. The only escalation is the 00:52 pops, and only on the dispatched-and-alone branch.

SP 3 Mill Camp Road

MOOD — READ THE ROOM

Mood (table): *Eight houses on wet gravel with not one light in them, and no wind and no downed limb to explain it — the rain stopped an hour ago and the row is just standing there. A woman is out on her step with a kerosene lamp and a coat over her nightclothes. Across the mill road the yard fence is a black edge, and well back behind it something hard and white is burning, with an engine under it.*

- **Goal:** confirm the outage is not weather and is not kids, put a person behind the telephone call, and turn her toward the fence on evidence rather than on a hunch.
- **Situation now:** reachable when she drives west out of town on 328 and turns onto the gravel loop at

the mill camp — six to seven minutes from the precinct in the day car. The row has been dark since a little after 00:08. **RITA HOLM** is on her step; **GIL SORENSON** at No. 6 has been out to the road twice and has decided the light in the yard is a work light. If the call went out, **KEVIN ALDER** reaches the mill camp and Rita at about 00:35 and spends roughly six minutes here before the fence.

- **Spoken lines (Rita Holm):** *"The mill and us are the same wire. Always have been. It goes, we go." "Three, four nights a month. Late. Going east, loaded. That's what I called about Friday."*
- **Spoken lines (Gil Sorenson):** *"That's not a flashlight. That's a work light."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Persuasion with Rita Holm	She repeats the complaint she has already made twice tonight.	She gives the shared feed — mill and houses on one wire, always — and that she called Friday about trucks.	She gives times: the lights went a little after ten past twelve, the trucks run three or four nights a month between midnight and two, and they go east.
Notice from the road	Dark houses and no storm. She has confirmed an outage and nothing else.	Light inside the fence, well back by the spur: hard, white, fixed — not a flashlight — with an engine under it.	She also separates a diesel idling from a small two-stroke, and places the light at the loading deck on the far side of the stacks rather than at the mill office by the gate.
Notice (-2) on the mill road gravel	Wet gravel and standing water.	Heavy dual-wheel tracks turning in at the rail-spur road rather than the main gate, in tonight.	Two sets: one laid down tonight and an older ridge underneath it, holding its shape under the new water. This has happened before.

- **Pressure/escalation:** standing on the road is safe and stays safe. What advances is the load, eighty yards away: copper is already aboard, the deck plate is going on, and the inland track has not been driven yet. A radio call from here reaches the base set cleanly; her portable is patchy out at the fence and much worse inside the yard.
- **Essential information and vectors:** the yard and the mill-camp houses share the company-built West End feed, so the houses going dark means something happened on the yard side; the outage began a little after 00:08; there is working light and a running engine inside a closed mill; Earl Voss's car is not on the street the roster says it should be. Independent vectors: Rita Holm; Gil Sorenson; the dark row against a lit town; the light and engine

noise inside the fence; the dual-wheel tracks at the spur road; the power company's Rookton answering service (no truck before 2 a.m.; trouble on the mill lateral).

- **Failure changes:** none physical. Missing the tracks or the engine note costs her the reversal in advance — she walks up to the fence expecting a power cut and finds a load-out instead.
- **Reachable next points:** SP4 at the fence; SP5 if she goes straight through the gate; back to SP1's radio room for Doyle, Rook County, or an ambulance she has not called yet.
- **Optional / PC hook:** none required.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: Sloat pulled the pole cutout at the yard fence at 00:08 so Ned could cut into the motor-room bus bar without it being live; nobody intended to black out the houses and nobody has thought about them since. Rita's Friday complaint is the sheet in the precinct basket.

On the radio: the car radio, still clear this far west; nothing broadcast points at the yard, which has gone dark and silent to any signal.

§ AT-HAND RULES

Authority: core Notice and Persuasion; no hazard exists on this ground. Quick reminder: nothing on Mill Camp Road can hurt her. If shooting starts inside the fence, the tenants stay indoors and one of them telephones again. Applied here: this is the last stop before Dark (-4) illumination rules begin to apply at the fence; see SP4's at-hand rules.

SP 4 Fence Line and Earl's Nest**MOOD — READ THE ROOM**

Mood (table): *The gate chain hangs loose and the mill office door stands open the way a door stands open when its latch gave up years ago. A primer-gray pickup is nosed in beside it. Twenty yards on, a police cruiser sits in the open bay of the scale house with its windows fogged from the inside and a radio muttering under the glass. Past it, sixty yards of wet gravel with nothing on it, and then the stacks.*

- **Goal:** deliver the reversal in a place where she can still choose — the crew, the truck, the missing watchman's vehicle, a sleeping patrolman, and the last moment before the yard becomes lethal.
- **Situation now:** reachable when she comes up the mill road to the yard fence, with Kevin, ahead of him, or after him. **LEN PELL** opened the main gate at 21:30 and never closed it. **EARL VOSS** has been

asleep in car 1 since about 23:50 and will sleep until roughly 5 a.m. or until something wakes him. The crew came in at the spur gate at 23:25 and is eighty yards away at the loading deck behind a running generator with the stacks between them and the scale house; they are not watching this gate and have worked around the sleeping cruiser for months.

- **Spoken lines (Kevin, on the air or at her window):** *"Camp's black and there's a light in the yard. Earl's not answering and I've called him twice."* If asked a real question about the highway: *"Eleven since February. Flatbeds, tarped, going east. What was I going to write?"*
- **Spoken lines (Earl, woken):** *"Len's truck's been sitting there since before I shut my eyes."* Pushed toward the gate: *"Call Kevin. This is Kevin's."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Notice at the fence line	She has light, an engine, and movement — she cannot say how many men or what they are loading.	Four men, a flatbed backed to the deck, a pickup at the spur gate, a work light on the deck rail, copper and plate going aboard.	She also places the man who is not working — JIMMY SLOAT, standing off the light with a long gun — and picks out the primer-gray F-100 by the mill office.
Notice inside the mill office	The office is as dead as it has been for four years.	The nail behind the door is empty and there is a fresh wet boot track on the floor.	Len's thermos is on the desk and still warm — cold inside another forty minutes, which is a clock she can read.
Persuasion or Intimidation waking Earl Voss	He is awake, frightened, and wants it to be Kevin's problem. He will not leave the car.	He gives what he actually saw: Len's truck in before 23:10, nothing since, and he has heard nothing at all.	He stays useful — works the radio to the base set and Rook County, or puts car 1 across the spur gate. He still will not walk into the yard, and he has nothing to confess, because there is nothing.

- **Pressure/escalation:** on the dispatched-and-alone branch only, Kevin crosses the apron at about 00:52 and is fired on; the shots wake Earl. If Lilly is here with him, the crew sees two lights instead of one and Meeks starts thinking about leaving rather than shooting — the truck can go before a shot is fired. If nobody was ever dispatched, the fence is quiet until she walks up to it herself. In every version, the moment anyone in the work light's cone knows a badge is on the fence, Meeks's go-clock starts.
- **Essential information and vectors:** four men, a loaded flatbed, a second vehicle, and working light inside a mill closed since 1984 — this is theft in progress, not an outage; Len Pell's truck is inside the gate and the key nail is empty, so the watchman is on this ground somewhere; Earl has been asleep since about 23:50 and saw Len's truck arrive well before that. Independent vectors: the light, the winch, and the diesel; Len's F-100 and the empty nail; Earl Voss's memory; Kevin's eleven counted flatbeds — first on Wednesday 5 February, most recent on Saturday 3 May, never written down, no plates — every one on a Wednesday or a Saturday; the spur-gate chain, cut months ago and rehung with a padlock that is **not** the Rennicks' (Meeks carries the key); the pulled pole cutout at the fence.
- **Failure changes:** being seen early costs surprise and starts Meeks's go-clock — the crew drops the winch and takes escape positions. Gunfire is not the cost of being seen; the cost is a truck that is already leaving. **Do not force shots at the fence when Lilly and Kevin are together.** Waking Earl badly costs a minute and a witness who is no use; it does not alert the crew, eighty yards away behind a running generator.
- **Reachable next points:** SP5 through the main gate, along the fence to the spur, or up the inland track; SP3 if she withdraws to the road to call; SP6 regardless of how SP5 ends.
- **Optional / PC hook:** none required.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: Earl is asleep, not bought. He has no envelope, no arrangement, and nothing to confess, and he does not know his own postings are worth anything to anyone. Treat the obvious conclusion — the sleeping cop is on the take — as a fair and wrong read; see `secrets.md`, NHE-05.

On the radio: car 2's radio and the muttering base set under the fogged glass of car 1; no cue reaches past the fence — the yard's own light has been dark since 00:08.

× AT-HAND STATISTICS

Nothing at this gate can shoot her (Encounter 1, encounters.md). The only man who might fire from this ground is **Jimmy Sloat**, and only on the dispatched-and-alone branch when Kevin crosses the apron at 00:52. His complete profile, and the rest of the crew's, are in SP5, where the actual fight happens. Kevin Alder's profile is also in SP5's at-hand statistics.

§ AT-HAND RULES

Authority: The Drop p.100; Surprise p.108. Full Illumination (p.102) and Cover (p.99) tables for the whole yard, including this gate's own features, live once in SP5's at-hand rules — do not re-derive them here. **Dark applies from here in.** She is not visible to the crew past a short range in the dark; this is a limit on seeing things in the dark, not on watching the lit deck from range — the Notice raise above, which picks Sloat out at range, is not restricted by it. Of SP5's Cover table, only the office wall, Len's F-100, the scale-house block, and the fence line apply at this gate. **There is no cover at all on the sixty-yard apron. When the crew fires (a GM decision, not a roll):** Meeks's standing order is that nobody shoots a police officer over scrap. Sloat fires only when all three hold at once — something moving at the deck he cannot resolve, one shout ("Stay off the deck!") unanswered, and Meeks has not called a stop. He does **not** fire if there are visibly two badges (two lights, two voices, a marked car at the gate), if an officer is standing still in the open and identified, or once Meeks has started the go-clock and said the word. **Two badges buy a departure, not a firefight.** Applied here: the mill-office door has never latched and swings on its own; do not call for Thievery or a Strength roll on it.

On this ground the fight is optional, not required. Full crew stat blocks, the yard's

cover/illumination tables, and Len's treatment clock live once, ahead, in Story Point 5.

SP 5 The Load-Out

MOOD — READ THE ROOM

Mood (table): *One clamp lamp on the loading-deck rail cuts a hard white cone about twenty-five yards across and makes everything outside it blacker than it was. Inside the cone men are working a hand winch onto a flatbed, unhurried, talking in short words, and a generator is running on the bed of a pickup by the spur gate. Everywhere else there are stacks, wet rope, standing water between the sheds, and a long blind row of shed doors.*

- **Goal:** the climax home — stop or shape the load-out, find Len alive, keep the powder off the truck, take the crew rather than scatter it, and leave a scene that can be written.
- **Situation now:** reachable when she crosses the fence line, by the main gate, along the fence to the rail spur, or up the inland track to the magazine. Copper bus bar and cable and four bundles of deck plate are already roped aboard. **DALE RUNKLE** and **JIMMY SLOAT** are on the winch; **ROY MEEKS** is on the deck checking the load and the time; **NED COLFAX** has not been right since 00:02 and keeps looking back at the shed row. **LEN**

PELL is behind the dropped bar on dry kiln No. 2, out of the light. Where the six cases of old powder are depends entirely on the clock — see the nested location below. None of these four men came here to shoot a police officer, and all four will if they are cornered between the deck and the fence.

- **Spoken lines (Meeks, to his own men, not to her):** *"Rope it. We're going."* If a badge is on the fence: *"Nobody fires on a cop over copper. Rope it."* To a police officer, once: *"Scrap. That's the charge you've got. Write that one."*
- **Spoken lines (Sloat, into the dark, before he fires):** *"Stay off the deck!"* A second challenge if he has reason to doubt: *"Say something! Say something or I'm shooting!"*
- **Spoken lines (Ned Colfax, taken or cornered):** *"He came round the sheds. He wasn't supposed to be here. Nobody's supposed to be here."* Once he cannot leave, unsigned and never repeated: *"We were told the lot's clear Wednesdays and Saturdays."*
- **Spoken lines (Len, if still conscious):** *"Whoever that is — the bar's on the outside."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Notice (-2) searching the shed row in the dark	The shed row is one long identical wall and she loses two minutes to it. Len's banging, if he is still conscious, gives him away anyway inside thirty yards.	Blood on the concrete apron and a 24-inch pry bar dropped where it was thrown.	The bar came down across the latch of kiln No. 2 and the door bar is down — she can open it without searching the rest of the row.
Notice on the flatbed's load	Tarped freight, roped down, nothing legible.	Copper bus bar, cable, and mill deck plate — a professional load, not a night's scavenging.	Stencilled wooden cases under the tarp, or the empty space and fresh drag marks where they are about to go, plus the cut hasp track up the inland corner.
Persuasion or Intimidation with Ned Colfax, once he cannot leave	He gives his name and asks to talk to somebody in Rookton. He says it anyway tomorrow, in a cell, to her or to Doyle — the vector survives at a cost in time and in how the morning goes.	He gives the shape of it — months, a Rookton man running it, himself hired for what he knows about the buildings, his bar that hit the watchman — and the line , unsigned and never repeated: they were told the lot was clear on Wednesdays and Saturdays. Pushed for who told them, he stops talking.	He can date and place it: Meeks said it to him at hire in November 1985, in one sentence, and it has held every Wednesday and Saturday since without a single exception. He still has no name, because he never asked for one and was never given one.
Common Knowledge on the cases	Wooden crates.	Old blasting supply, left over from company road work, and old blasting supply is not safe blasting supply.	She can say why it matters out loud: badly stored stock sweats, and it is going onto a flatbed that is about to drive 22 miles of two-lane.

- **Pressure/escalation:** Meeks's only objective is the truck on 328. He gives up copper before he gives up the truck, and the truck before a man to a shooting charge. His go-clock starts at first police contact of any kind — not the first shot, and not a fixed hour — and runs fifteen to twenty minutes to wheels-up, with 01:45 as the outside limit; the familiar 01:10 is only what that produces when contact happens at 00:52. If the flatbed gets moving, the spur road puts it on 328 eastbound in under a minute. Every minute on the firefight is a minute off Len's clock and a minute the pickup is on the inland track.
- **Essential information and vectors:** this is months of organized salvage, not one night's raid; Len is alive behind kiln No. 2 and on a clock; there is old blasting stock in this yard and it is moving toward the truck; one of these men was told this lot is safe on Wednesdays and Saturdays, and he will not say by whom. Independent vectors: the load itself; the cut-and-rehung spur chain and the older tire ridge on the mill road; Ned Colfax's line; Kevin's eleven flatbeds; Rita Holm's three-or-four-nights-a-month; Len, if he is found able to talk; the magazine's cut hasp and drag marks.
- **Failure changes:** she can win the yard and lose the powder, hold the powder and lose the truck, take the crew and find Len too late, or go down and wake up with Kevin dragging her behind the scale house and the load gone. None of these closes the case. The yard, the magazine, the spur chain, the tire ridge, Rita's call, the roster, and the fold all still exist in the morning.
- **Reachable next points:** SP6 in every case.
- **Optional / PC hook:** none required. Confrontation, containment, withdrawal, and evidence priorities all stay player choices.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: Ned swung the pry bar at 00:02 in a panic and has been useless since. Meeks pays a local go-between for the quiet and has never met a police officer about it; he believes a day of the week is a guarantee and is finding out tonight that it is not. None of these four can name Chief Whitley, because none of them has ever been told (secrets.md, NHE-01, NHE-04).

THE INLAND TRACK AND THE MAGAZINE

A different door — about 400 yards inland of the yard's back corner, up a rutted track through second growth, and out of sight and earshot of the deck for anything but engine noise. Reachable at any point once she is inside the fence; the clock inside this door runs whether or not she ever walks up it.

- Sensory frame: the track leaves the gravel and turns into two ruts full of water under second growth that closes over the top of it. At the end there is a low concrete box with a steel door, a cut hasp hanging off it, and moss to the roofline. Inside, the smell is sweet and oily and wrong, and it is colder than the night outside.
- People and forces: nobody until Runkle drives up. Meeks stays at the loading deck while Runkle makes all three trips.
- Environment/hazards: soft ruts after rain — Difficult Ground on foot, 2" of Pace per inch (p.92) — and a real prospect of bogging a loaded pickup. Pitch Darkness (–6) under the second growth with no light brought in; Dim (–2) in whatever beam anyone carries. The bunker is concrete: Heavy to Near Total Cover, +10 as Armor if it stops a hit.

- Spoken lines: Runkle, backing the pickup, to nobody: *"Slow. Slow. Slow."* If a light is on the track ahead of him: *"I'm stopped. I'm stopped, look — I'm stopped."* Ned, if present and thinks anyone is about to drive it: *"That stuff up the track is seventy-eight. You don't put seventy-eight on a truck."*
- Discoverable: none unique here beyond the parent table above — the Notice on the flatbed's load and Common Knowledge on the cases already cover reading this material.
- Changes if delayed: an empty bunker by about 01:10 unless somebody interferes. If the cases reach the flatbed and the truck goes, the powder leaves the county — a failure state this adventure is allowed to have.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: Runkle wants three two-case loads down the track without bogging the pickup, between about 00:45 and 01:10. Until about 00:45 all six cases are still in the bunker; each trip afterward puts two in transit while earlier loads wait at the flatbed; all six are roped under the tarp only after about 01:10. **Do not assert it is already on the flatbed before that.** Standing on the track is enough to secure it and needs no roll — Runkle will not drive at a badge.

§ AT-HAND RULES — THE POWDER

Finding and reading it, handling it, driving the track, and securing it are all ordinary Trait tests already covered in the parent Discoverable table and above; do not add new rolls. **Burning** is fully covered by Fire (SWADE p.127): a flammable target hit by fire catches on a d6 roll of 6, a very flammable one on 4–6, a volatile one on 2–6; the Fire Damage table runs 1d6 spot contact / 2d6 burning room / 3d6 flamethrower.

Question. If a round strikes a case, a case is dropped or driven off the pickup bed, or fire reaches the bunker with the taped tin of caps in it, does anything detonate tonight — and if so, with what damage, template, and how many cases? **Sources checked.** SWADE Fifth Printing (2023): p.34 Repair covers demolitions but supplies no yield; pp.78–79 print only military grenades and mines, tagged Heavy Weapon; pp.97–98 Area Effect/Blast Templates are delivery methods with no yield for this material; p.127 Fire covers burning, not detonation; p.125 Hazards has no explosion entry. No setting module is active; HR-NFA-001/002 do not touch explosives. There is no SWADE profile for commercial blasting agent, caps, or degraded stock. **Decision: Option A — no detonation tonight.** The cases burn under Fire (p.127) and never go off. The hazard is fire, smoke, a building to get people out of, and a 22-mile ambulance. Every clock, vector, and end state in this adventure works under this ruling. Recorded as RUL–2026–09–21–01 in rules/rulings.md. **Regardless, prep never detonates this on its own** — only a player or crew action can trigger it.

× **AT-HAND STATISTICS**

All four crew members are **Extras**: one Wound Incapacitates (p.95), they roll a single Trait die with no Wild Die (pp.87–88). Built freehand under SWADE's Creating Extras guidance (p.202). No opposing Wild Card appears on this yard.

ROY MEEKS – Extra

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d8, Spirit d8, Strength d6, Vigor d6

Skills: Athletics d4, Common Knowledge d6, Driving d8, Fighting d4, Intimidation d8, Notice d6, Persuasion d6, Repair d4, Shooting d6, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; Parry: 4; Toughness: 5

Hindrances: none needed at table

Edges: none

Gear: Police Revolver (.38) in his coat – 10/20/40, 2d6, AP –, RoF 1, Shots 6, reloaded one round at a time (p.74); flatbed keys; spur-gate padlock key; work gloves; a watch he keeps checking

Special Abilities: none

Personality: arithmetic, not anger. Gives up the small charge fast to keep clear of the large one.

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 74, 87–88, 95, 202

NED COLFAX – Extra

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d6, Spirit d4, Strength d8, Vigor d6

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d6, Driving d4, Fighting d4, Notice d6, Persuasion d4, Repair d8, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; Parry: 4; Toughness: 5

Hindrances: none needed at table

Edges: none

Gear: bolt cutters, cable knife, flashlight, mill coat. **No firearm.** The 24-inch pry bar is lying across the latch of dry kiln No. 2 where he threw it at 00:02; if he ever picks it up it is a Medium improvised weapon – Range 2/4/8, Damage Str+d6, Min Str d6, –2 to the attack roll (p.102)

Special Abilities: none

Personality: will not fight and will not run well. Talks about the job freely and stops dead on who guaranteed the day of the week.

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 87–88, 95, 102, 202

DALE RUNKLE – Extra

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d8, Vigor d8

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d4, Driving d8, Fighting d6, Notice d4, Repair d4, Shooting d4, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; Parry: 5; Toughness: 6

Hindrances: none needed at table

Edges: none

Gear: crew-cab pickup with the generator on the bed; chains, rope, hand winch; Ruger (.22) **in the driver's door pocket, not on his person** – 10/20/40, 2d4, AP –, RoF 1, Shots 9 (p.74)

Special Abilities: none

Personality: talks to the truck. Will not drive at a badge and will not fight over somebody else's load.

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 74, 87–88, 95, 202

JIMMY SLOAT – Extra

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d6, Vigor d6

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d4, Driving d6, Fighting d4, Notice d6, Shooting d6, Stealth d6

Pace: 6; Parry: 4; Toughness: 5

Hindrances: none needed at table

Edges: none

Gear: Pump Action shotgun – 12/24/48, Damage 3d6/2d6/1d6 at Short/Medium/Long range, RoF 1, Shots 6, Min Str d4 (pp.74, 105); a coat pocket of shells, reloaded one shell as a free action once per action (p.105)

Special Abilities: Shotgun (p.105) – **+2 to Shooting at Short range only** (inside 12"/24 yards); at Medium and Long he rolls with ordinary range penalties and no bonus. On a miss, each skill die showing a 1 or a 2 may hit a bystander in or adjacent to the line of fire (p.102) – which matters with Kevin, Earl, or Ned nearby.

Personality: shouts a boundary before he does anything. Fires at noise and movement, not at people he has identified.

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 74, 87–88, 95, 102, 105, 202

LEN PELL – Extra; behind the barred door of dry kiln No. 2

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d6, Spirit d6, Strength d6, Vigor d6

Skills: Athletics d4, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d4, Notice d6, Persuasion d4, Repair d6, Shooting d4, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; Parry: 4; Toughness: 5

Gear: Rennick key on his belt; flashlight, dropped on the kiln apron

Current state: one Wound and therefore Incapacitated (p.95) since 00:02 – see the treatment clock below.

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 87–88, 95, 202

KEVIN ALDER – Extra; Ashgrove PD night patrol

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d6, Spirit d6, Strength d6, Vigor d6

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d6, Driving d8, Fighting d6, Notice d6, Persuasion d4, Shooting d6, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; Parry: 5; Toughness: 5

Gear: service revolver – Police Revolver (.38), 10/20/40, 2d6, AP –, RoF 1, Shots 6 (p.74); flashlight; portable and car radio; car 2

Authority: SWADE Fifth Printing (2023), pp.10–11, 74, 87–88, 95, 202

Earl Voss has no written statistics and does not need any: by prep he stays in or behind car 1, holds a radio, and takes no action that would be rolled.

§ AT-HAND RULES — THE YARD

Illumination (p.102): the whole yard outside the work light is **Dark, -4** — targets are not visible outside 10" (20 yards). Inside the 500-watt clamp lamp's cone (~25 yards, ~12") is **Dim, -2 (GM's call — p.102 prints no clamp-lamp row)**. The shed row, a closed kiln, or the bunker with no light brought in is **Pitch Darkness, -6**. Anything a flashlight or headlight is actually on is **Dim, -2 in that beam (GM's call)**. **Distances (1" = 2 yards):** main gate → first stacks 60 yd/30", no cover; main gate → loading deck 80 yd/40"; fence → scale house 20 yd/10"; work-light cone across ~25 yd/12"; Len banging audible at ~30 yd/15"; yard's back corner → magazine 400 yd/200". A pump shotgun's Short range is 12" (24 yards) and a .38's is 10" (20 yards) — in the dark, almost every shot the crew takes lands at Short range. **Cover (p.99), features mapped to printed rows:** banded lumber stack -6/-8, Armor +10 (stone wall); bundled deck plate on the flatbed -4/-6, Armor +10 (stone wall); flatbed/pickup/car bodies -4, Armor +4 (sheet metal); loading-deck timber edge -4, Armor +6 (oak door); drying-shed board wall -4, Armor +2 (drywall); scale-house block -4/-6, Armor +6 (cinder block); dry kiln wall/door -6, Armor +8 (brick); magazine bunker -6/-8, Armor +10 (stone wall); the 60-yard apron has none. **Footing, noise, radio:** wet gravel, standing water, about 46°F. Call Athletics only where the fiction crosses something real — a deck edge, a kiln apron, a stack face; failure is prone or out of position, never invented damage. The generator covers ordinary noise at the gate but not a shot, a shout, or a car door. Lilly's portable is patchy at the fence and worse inside the yard; the car radio at the mill road works. **Lilly's own gear:** her canonical sheet is authority and this file does not change it. A Kevlar Vest is Armor +2 and reduces bullet/shot damage by a further 4 (p.70), converting most Short-range hits back to Shaken against her Toughness — at a cost of -1 Pace and Agility-linked skills while worn (Min Str d6, p.66). Her 9mm is pinned to Glock (9mm) — 12/24/48, 2d6, AP 1, RoF 1, Shots 17 (p.74) — on her canonical sheet (. /characters/lilly-dawson.md).

§ AT-HAND RULES — LEN PELL'S CLOCK

He took a 24-inch pry bar above the left ear at 00:02. One Wound Incapacitates him (p.95); p.95 leaves consciousness to the GM, and this prep decides it: **he is Incapacitated and not Bleeding Out, and he is conscious until roughly 01:05, unconscious after** — matching plot.md's Len clock. He can talk and bang the door while conscious-and-Incapacitated; he cannot take a useful action until treated. **The Golden Hour (p.96)** closes at about **01:02** (injury at 00:02). Reached and treated by then: Healing, 10 minutes per Wound level, -1 without a first-aid kit; success removes the Wound and the Incapacitated state — he can stand with help and hold a flashlight. Reached between about 00:52 and 01:02: not enough time remains to complete the 10-minute procedure before the window closes; do not roll it. Reached 01:02-01:05: the Golden Hour has closed; no Healing roll can remove the Wound; get him warm and to the ambulance. Reached 01:05-02:00: unconscious, breathing, cold; survival resolves on a Vigor roll under Aftermath & Extras (p.96), no modifier. Reached after about 02:00, or found by Kevin or Earl later: the same Vigor roll at a **GM's-call -2** for elapsed exposure — **this is the branch where he can die, and it is elapsed time doing it, not prep**. The printed Cold hazard (p.125, below-freezing) does not apply at ~46°F; the -2 above is the only non-printed number in this procedure. Rookton is about 22 miles distant: Rook County's ambulance is about 30 minutes out and 30 back, and a Rook County deputy is 35-40 minutes out — calling either early costs nothing and is the single most useful thing Lilly can do for Len before she ever finds him.

If the flatbed rolls: Meeks's go-clock runs out, or the spur road is open and he decides the copper aboard is enough. Her call — block the spur road, take the men on the ground, or follow. **Do not force a Chase subsystem** (GM.md); if nobody is in a position to pursue, the truck simply leaves and the night moves to SP6. If a pursuit is genuinely active, run SWADE's Chases (p.113) with named substitutions stated aloud

before play — Mid-Sized Car (Handling 0, Toughness 11(2)) for the day car; Semi-Truck (Handling 0, Top Speed 75, Toughness 14(2)) or Sports Utility Vehicle (Handling 0, Toughness 14(2), 4WD) as the nearest printed analogues for the flatbed or pickup. No printed 1970s flatbed row exists; do not invent one. Part or all of the load leaving the county is a failure state this adventure is allowed to have (plot.md, end states).

MOOD — READ THE ROOM

Mood (table): *Grey light comes through the windows with the smell of the first pot of coffee, and the day shift arrives to a story that is already ahead of them. Her own handwriting from 00:20 sits at the top of the radio log. On the shelf beside the phone the patrol basket has not been touched since yesterday evening, and the sheet on top of it is folded in half with one crease down it.*

- **Goal:** close a real case, deliver the fold callback, and leave her certain her chief is protecting that lot and unable to prove it.
- **Situation now:** reachable when she leaves the yard, or when the night ends without her reaching it. Whatever she brought back — men in the two cells, a flatbed, six cases nobody wants to move in the dark, Len in Rookton or not — turns into an ordinary salvage file that a chief can sign, with a shooting on it only if shots were actually fired.

WHITLEY comes in about seven, hears it from **SGT. DOYLE** before he hears it from her, and backs her loudly in front of the day shift. He signs the salvage close. He does not shrink anything, and by Monday the arrangement is quietly over.

- **Spoken lines (Whitley, if all four men were taken):** *"My detective took four men off that lot with one patrolman and no help from anybody. Write that down somewhere it'll get read."* If fewer than four: *"My detective worked that lot with what this town gave her. Put what she brought home at the top of the report."* At his desk with the file: *"Sign it and I'll sign it. Overtime too."* On a raise, before she has told him where Earl was: *"Was Voss on the lot?"*
- **Spoken lines (Doyle):** *"You had the room, you had the phone, and you rolled. That's the whole report."*
- **Discoverable:**

Trait	Fail	Success	Raise ★
Notice at the radio-room shelf	The basket is full of patrol paper and she walks past it. It is still there tomorrow.	The folded sheet is in it, heading tucked, one crease, Ref. patrol – Voss in pencil.	She matches the crease to the fold she watched him make at 18:10 and reads the heading she was not meant to read: Rita Holm, No. 4 Mill Camp Road, trucks at the mill at night.
Research in the dead-paper rooms (HR-NFA-002, Hitting the Books)	An hour gone; the weekly assignment sheets are bundled by month in no order inside them.	She reconstructs the Wednesday and Saturday postings back to 1 January 1986: Earl on West End and the mill, Kevin east on 328 or the lake road, every time.	The exact count — 37 of the 39 Wednesday and Saturday nights this year, the two exceptions being the week Earl was out sick — against Kevin drawing West End 17 times on other nights of the week and never once on a Wednesday or a Saturday. Her own six Wednesday and Saturday tricks since January were all in town or at the lake.
Persuasion with Whitley over the file	He praises her anyway and signs the close. By Monday the original complaint is gone out of the basket; Nancy's carbon is still in the Friday day file.	He gives her the file, the overtime, and a free hand on the salvage case without an argument.	He asks one question he should not have needed to ask — whether Voss was on the lot — before she has told him where Earl was. A chief asking after his patrolman. She will not be able to make it mean anything on paper.

- **Pressure/escalation:** delay costs the original sheet, not the fact — the folded complaint is out of the basket by Monday, though Nancy's carbon survives in the Friday day file. Nothing new appears

later; the vectors do not ripen into evidence tonight or in the morning.

- **Essential information and vectors:** the salvage file stands on its own and will survive a morning's

- reading; the mill-noise complaint was referred to patrol and folded on Friday, hours before a load-out on the same lot; Earl on West End every Wednesday and Saturday is a pattern in the building's own paper; Kevin's eleven trucks were never written down. Independent vectors: the folded complaint; Nancy Iverson's carbon; the weekly assignment sheets in the dead-paper rooms; Ned Colfax's unsigned line; Kevin Alder's count; Rita Holm's Friday call; her own radio-room log. None of it is proof of anything.
- **Failure changes:** there is no branch in which she walks out of the morning uncertain about her chief. Missing all four vectors costs her the language she would use on paper; it does not cost her the certainty — the suspicion floor alone guarantees that.
 - **Reachable next points:** complete ending. Evidence and the unfair walk belong to night 4 (ashgrove-puzzle-1986).

- **Optional / PC hook:** none required.

GM ONLY — DO NOT READ ALOUD

GM Note: he is not performing. He is genuinely pleased, genuinely finished with the arrangement, and genuinely never going to be touched by tonight. Do not let him confess, slip a name, or behave like a man who knows he has been read. His behaviour here is the third unmissable piece of the **suspicion floor**: controlled dawn praise, in public, for work on a lot he personally steered her away from twelve hours earlier. That lands whether or not she picks up a single vector and whether or not a round was fired, and it is still not proof of anything (plot.md, the suspicion floor; secrets.md, NHE-01).

On the radio: the precinct radio at the morning changeover, ordinary rotation audible under the day shift's noise; it returns the room to daily life without answering anything.

§ AT-HAND RULES

Authority: core Persuasion and Research; HR-NFA-002 Hitting the Books for the assignment sheets (Deadlands Noir, PEG 2012, p.29, converted to SWADE Research). Quick reminder: nothing in this room is a threat. A failed Research roll here costs an hour, not the fact. Applied here: **NOT FILEABLE TONIGHT** — no ledger, signed statement, cash in hand, confession, or chain-of-command packet may result from any roll in this situation. The four vectors sharpen how much language she has; they do not decide whether she is certain.

Optional GM lookups

CONTACT STATES AT A GLANCE

Dispatch decides who is west; whether Kevin is alone decides whether the 00:52 shots fire. Use whichever state the table's choices produced.

State	What happened	00:41 (Kevin transmits)	00:52 (shots)
Dispatched, Kevin alone	Lilly answers at 00:20, puts it on the air, stays on Main or with paperwork	Fires — light in the yard, a truck, then he stops transmitting	Fires — Sloat drives him back with two rounds; Earl wakes
Dispatched, Lilly with him or already at the fence	Kevin is west but not crossing the apron alone	May still fire if he arrives first	Does not fire. Meeks sees two lights and starts the go-clock instead
No dispatch	She is already on Main at 00:20, or walks out without raising anybody	Does not apply	Does not fire — nobody is at the fence to fire at. Rita tries again at 00:41, sends Gil Sorenson at about 00:55, and Kevin reaches the mill camp on his ordinary loop at about 01:20

THE FOUR GRAFT VECTORS, SIDE BY SIDE

Any combination sharpens how much Lilly could write down; none is required, because the suspicion floor lands regardless (plot.md, the suspicion floor).

Vector	Where it lives	What it gives
The fold and its carbon	SP1, SP6	The folded complaint in the PATROL – READ basket; Nancy Iverson's carbon in the Friday day file
The assignment sheets	SP6	37 of 39 Wednesday/Saturday nights to Earl; 17 other-night postings and zero Wed/Sat postings to Kevin; Lilly's own six Wed/Sat tricks all in town or at the lake
Ned Colfax's unsigned line	SP5	"We were told the lot's clear Wednesdays and Saturdays" — once, unsigned, no name, on a success only
Kevin's eleven flatbeds	SP4, SP5, SP6	Eleven heavy tarped flatbeds on ORE. 328 since February, east toward Rookton, midnight–two, every one on a Wednesday or a Saturday

Escalation and clocks

Pressure model for the GM, not a timetable to enforce against the table. Every entry below is what happens **if**

nothing interferes; player action moves all of it.

Time	What is happening (undisturbed)
17:00	Nancy Iverson goes home; the town line switches to the night line.
18:10	Whitley folds Friday's complaint and hands Lilly the Daisy's overflow (SP1).
18:25	Whitley drops the sheet in the PATROL – READ basket and drives home for the night.
18:30	The Hoot Owl starts turning walk-ins away for Oscar Lind's send-off supper.
19:30	Daisy's is full and stays full (SP2).
21:30	Len Pell's F-100 goes through the mill gate; the Rennick key nail goes empty.
23:10	Earl Voss clears West End on the air and backs into the scale-house bay. Asleep by about 23:50.
23:25	The crew comes in at the rail-spur gate.
23:50	Ned walks Meeks up the inland track and cuts the magazine hasp.
00:02	Len walks into the work light; Ned panics and swings the pry bar. Kiln No. 2's bar drops.
00:08	Sloat pulls the pole cutout; the yard's last lamps and the mill-camp houses go dark together (SP3).
00:20	Rita Holm telephones the precinct (SP1 Phase B).
00:21	Only if dispatched. Kevin turns west from 328 near Lowater — 12–14 minutes to the mill camp, 6–7 to the precinct.
00:41	Dispatched line only. Kevin reaches the fence (SP4).
00:45–01:10	Runkle makes three two-case pickup trips up the inland track (SP5, nested magazine location).
00:52	Dispatched-and-alone line only. Kevin crosses the open apron and is fired on; Earl wakes — see Contact states above.
01:02	Len's Golden Hour closes.
01:05	Len stops banging; unconscious after this point if unreached.
01:10	All six powder cases roped on the flatbed under the tarp, if undisturbed.
01:15	Lind's supper breaks up; the Owl empties onto Main.
01:45	Meeks's outside limit — wheels-up, whatever the state of the load. Police contact of any kind pulls this earlier; see the go-clock in Table terms.

Failure-forward reference

Likely failure	Immediate consequence	New pressure/opportunity	Main plot remains reachable through
The fold is missed at SP1	No cost tonight	The sheet and its carbon both survive to SP6	Nancy's carbon, the assignment sheets, Ned's line, Kevin's count
The night line is never answered	Rita rings again at 00:41, then sends Gil Sorenson	Kevin reaches the mill camp on his own loop at about 01:20 instead of 00:35	SP2's vectors; SP3 on arrival; the yard is nearly roped rather than untouched
Daisy's vectors go unworked	Time lost, nothing closed	Gil Sorenson at 01:00, or the Owl emptying at 01:15	SP3, SP4, and SP5 all still open independently
The tracks/engine note are missed at SP3	She loses the reversal in advance	She walks up expecting a power cut and finds a load-out instead	SP4's own Notice rolls at the fence
Kevin is dispatched and goes in alone	Fired on at 00:52; Earl wakes	Meeks's go-clock starts early	SP5 remains reachable; Kevin can still hold the scene
Ned Colfax's Persuasion/Intimidation roll fails	He gives only his name; the line waits for a cell tomorrow	Delays the graft vector, does not delete it	Kevin's count, the assignment sheets, the fold
Len is reached late	Unconscious, cold; Vigor roll with a GM's-call -2	This is the branch where he can die — a consequence of elapsed time, not prep	The case still closes on what is on the ground
The powder reaches the flatbed	Cases leave on ORE. 328 if the truck goes	A failure state the adventure is allowed to have	The yard, the magazine track, the crew, and the graft vectors all survive to the morning
Lilly is Incapacitated at the yard	Kevin drags her behind the scale house; the clock advances	Lost position, not a lost session	Doyle reachable by radio; Len is a pair of hands only after treatment
Whitley is never suspected on paper	No language for the morning report	The suspicion floor still lands regardless	Night 4 (ashgrove-puzzle-1986) owns proof and the unfair walk

PC spotlight and safety

- **Opening hard-removal risks and mitigation:** none. The precinct, Main Street, Daisy's, and the West End houses carry no lethal threat at all. The first danger is at the mill fence, and only after she chooses to approach it; the transition is announced by the fiction — light where there should be none, a diesel idling, men loading in the dark, sixty yards of gravel with nothing on it — not by a roll.
- **Point after which consequences become fully lethal:** the moment she crosses the fence line at SP4/SP5. Everyone in the crew is an Extra who would rather be on the highway than in a gunfight, dangerous only while cornered or panicking, and one of them has already panicked once tonight. The magazine is a hazard that can kill anyone, including the crew; it is a clock, never a scripted detonation.
- **Replacement/re-entry option:** no spare PC in this solo campaign. If Lilly is Incapacitated, resolve it normally (p.95) and hand the scene to **Kevin Alder**, who drags her behind the scale house while the clock advances and the load gets further gone — control returns after a short transition with lost position, not a lost session. **Sgt. Doyle** is reachable by radio at a cost of about 40 minutes to the fence. **Len Pell** is a pair of hands only after successful treatment removes his Wound, or if the table's fiction otherwise justifies equivalent support; opening the kiln alone is not enough. A terminal removal ends the night in a consequence-defined failure state; there is no replacement PC.
- **Capture or separation:** the crew shuts somebody in only long enough to move the truck — no hostages, no held ground. Give her the inside of

wherever she is put and return her to the night within a scene.

- **Spotlight hooks:** Shooting and Athletics in a dark yard; Notice/Alertness on the fold, the roster, and the nest; Investigator and Research in the morning's paper; Persuasion with Daisy, Ned Colfax, and Kevin; Danger Sense at the fence line. No essential clue, route, or objective depends on one skill, Edge,

or roll. HR-NFA-001 (Lilly's 15-skill-point build) shapes competence but changes no resolution tonight.

- **Safety:** Lines and Veils/check-in as used by the table. Likely content: a head injury and cold exposure, gunfire in the dark, a chief's ordinary corruption left unresolved. Keep injury description clinical unless the player requests otherwise.

NPC quick reference

- **Chief Whitley** — established police Extra, not statted; speech and the fold in SP1; closure and praise in SP6.
- **Sgt. Doyle** — established police Extra, not statted; reachable by radio from SP1 on; speech in SP6.
- **Nancy Iverson** — established civilian Extra, not statted; her carbon is a GM-only vector in SP6; off-scene tonight.
- **Kevin Alder** — Extra; start pin SP1 (radio); on scene from SP4; complete stat block in SP5.
- **Earl Voss** — unstatted by prep; asleep in car 1 from SP4; stays in or behind the car if the fight reaches him.
- **Len Pell** — Extra; first physical trace in SP4; found and spoken to in SP5; complete stat block and treatment clock in SP5.
- **Rita Holm** — established civilian Extra, not statted; speech in SP1 (phone) and SP3 (in person).
- **Gil Sorenson** — adventure-local civilian, not statted; optional vector in SP2 and SP3.
- **Pat Calhoun** — adventure-local civilian, not statted; seen only in the Owl doorway at 01:15, SP2.
- **Daisy Pell** — established civilian Extra, not statted; speech and vectors in SP2.
- **Marnie Quade** — GM-only; behind the Owl's bar all night; encountered only if Lilly walks into the private supper (`locations.md`, GM-only truth); passes no envelope tonight.
- **Roy Meeks** — Extra; start pin SP5 (visible once Lilly sees the deck); complete stat block in SP5.
- **Ned Colfax** — Extra; start pin SP5; complete stat block and interrogation notes in SP5.
- **Dale Runkle** — Extra; start pin SP5, primary presence in the nested magazine location; complete stat block in SP5.
- **Jimmy Sloat** — Extra; may fire as early as SP4 (dispatched-and-alone branch only); complete stat block in SP5.

Rules quick reference

Night-wide constants. Situation-specific procedure (this jump, this kit ask, this illumination at the deck) stays in the story point that rolls it.

- **Authority order:** HR-NFA-001/002 within scope, then SWADE Fifth Printing (2023). No setting module is active.
- **HR-NFA-001:** Lilly's canonical sheet uses 15 post-core skill points; it does not alter tonight's resolution.
- **HR-NFA-002:** optional Hitting the Books (Research), Interrogations (three-round Social Conflict for Ned Colfax), and Patter only. It does not activate *Deadlands Noir* as a setting and forbids Gritty Damage and Knock-Out Blows — this is a SWADE shooting, not a *Deadlands* one.
- **Extras:** one Wound Incapacitates (p.95). No opposing Wild Card appears on this yard; do not promote anyone.
- **Illumination and cover:** SWADE p.102 and p.99; full tables live once in SP5's at-hand rules and are referenced, not repeated, from SP4.
- **Called Shots (p.98):** -4 to hit, +4 damage for a called shot to the head or a named location; face of an open-faced helmet analogue does not apply here — no armor of that kind is in play.
- **Recoil (p.105):** applies only to weapons fired at their printed Rate of Fire above 1 without the Rock and Roll Edge; none of tonight's Extras use it, and Suppressive Fire is legal but unused by the crew (`encounters.md`, Encounter 2 adaptation notes).
- **Do not import:** Gritty Damage, Knock-Out Blows, Fear Levels, Noir Poverty, Blood & Guts, Harrowed, Magic, or anything from *Deadlands Noir Companion* as setting.
- **Weapons:** the crew's guns are on their SP5 stat blocks. Lilly's service pistol is on her canonical

sheet, pinned to Glock (9mm) — 12/24/48, 2d6, AP 1, RoF 1, Shots 17 (p.74).

- **The powder:** ruled Option A — no detonation tonight; the cases burn under Fire (p.127) only.

Recorded as RUL-2026-09-21-01 in rules/rulings.md. Full box in SP5's nested magazine location.

GM secrets

- **NHE-01 — The arrangement.** Whitley is paid cash, at a remove through Marnie Quade behind the Owl's bar, to keep the frozen Cinder Creek lot unpublished. He writes the assignment sheet himself: on Len's drinking nights (Wednesday and Saturday) Earl draws West End and the mill, Kevin is posted away, and Lilly draws something small. He steers; he never warns the crew directly, has never met a hauler, and believes he is being paid to look away from ordinary salvage. Nobody else in Ashgrove knows any of it. **NOT FILEABLE TONIGHT.**
- **NHE-02 — The powder in the bunker.** Six wooden cases of 1978 ammonia stumping powder, a taped tin of caps, and a coil of leg wire sit about 400 yards inland, never aired or cleared. Ned told Meeks about it tonight; Meeks intends to sell it in Rookton. Whitley does not know it exists — his guilt stays proportionate to scrap, not to explosives on a state highway.
- **NHE-03 — What happened to Len Pell.** At 00:02 Len walked into the work light; Ned panicked and swung the pry bar, catching him above the left ear. The crew dragged him into kiln No. 2 and dropped the outside bar. Nobody has looked at him since. He can give four men and a work light; he never saw who swung and cannot give a name.
- **NHE-04 — Meeks pays for the day of the week.** Meeks has run the lot in stages since November 1985 and was given the rule in one sentence at hire: Wednesdays and Saturdays, nobody walks it. He has never met a police officer about it and does not know a chief's name is attached. Ned heard the rule and never asked who guaranteed it. **NOT FILEABLE TONIGHT.**
- **NHE-05 — Earl Voss is a hole, not a conspirator.** Earl sleeps in the scale-house bay on the nights the sheet gives him West End and the mill — his spot on those nights, not every night. He has no envelope and nothing to confess, and would be insulted by the suggestion. Letting Lilly reach for the fair, wrong conclusion about him and then correct it herself is deliberate.
- **NHE-06 — Kevin Alder's eleven trucks.** Since February, Kevin has passed eleven heavy tarped flatbeds on ORE. 328, east toward Rookton, midnight to two, every one of them on a Wednesday or a Saturday — a pattern he has never noticed because nobody ever asked him what day it was. **NOT FILEABLE TONIGHT.**
- **The suspicion floor.** Not a discoverable clue: at about 18:10 the chief told her, in person, that the Cinder Creek lot was kids or Earl's business and handed her Main Street instead. Somewhere between midnight and dawn that same lot is revealed as a months-long organized load-out. In the morning the same man hears it from Doyle first, backs her loudly, signs the salvage close, and treats the night as finished police work needing no explanation. **Every ending therefore ends the same way: she is certain he is corrupt, and she cannot prove it.** Nothing tonight decides whether she leaves with proof, because there is none to get.
- **GM-only boundary.** Nothing in this night is supernatural, and nothing in this night's paper has been altered — no synchronization gap, no missing interval, no nausea, no ClearWave, no consortium, no Concordance operation anywhere in it. Whitley is ordinary small-town graft and knows nothing of any of it. Night 3 does not take Whitley off the force; evidence, channels, and the unfair walk belong to night 4 (ashgrove-puzzle-1986). Do not let any end state here produce a name above Roy Meeks.
- **Red herring, held fair:** the sleeping patrolman looks bought and is not (NHE-05). The Rennick split-title quarrel looks like a motive for stripping the lot; the Rookton haulers have no connection to the Rookton-side title holder, and the Rennicks stay off-screen.

End states

Every end state leaves Lilly **certain** that Whitley is protecting that lot and unable to prove it — the

suspicion floor guarantees that even in the branches where she picks up none of the four vectors. How many

vectors she reached decides how much she could write down if she were foolish enough to try; none of it is proof.

- **Full success:** the flatbed never leaves the spur, all four men are accounted for, the six cases stay in the county, and Len is warm and on his way to Rookton. The salvage case is hers and Whitley signs it with a compliment. Ned Colfax will talk about the job in a cell tomorrow and will still not say who told them the lot was clear.
- **Costly success:** the case closes, but somebody paid for it — Kevin or Len in the county hospital, or dead, or the powder east on 328 in exchange for four men and a truck.
- **Partial success:** part of the crew is taken and part is gone, or the load is stopped and the men are not. Enough is on the ground that the yard cannot be called kids, and not enough to finish the salvage case tonight.
- **Main-objective failure:** the flatbed reaches 328 with the load and the powder on it, the crew is

scattered, and the official story stays as small as it started. The yard, the magazine track, the cut chain, Rita's two calls, the roster, and the fold are all still there in the morning, and the arrangement survives intact into night 4.

- **Unexpected outcome:** Meeks trades the truck and his men for a road out; Earl does something in the last five minutes he can never explain; Ned walks up to the fence with his hands out before anyone fires; a case goes up on the inland track and rewrites the yard. Adjudicate what survives; do not let any of it produce a name above Roy Meeks.
- **Rewards / advancement:** no XP or Advance is named for this night. State at the table that the consequence itself — and the night-4 hinge, evidence and the unfair walk still to come — is the reward.
- **Continuing hook:** night 4 (ashgrove-puzzle-1986) is where the four graft vectors can become something, and where Whitley's unfair walk lands. Nights 1 and 2 (the lake, the tower, Abigail Carr) are unrelated and stay closed.

Table checklist

- [x] Runtime header matches ADVENTURE.md.
- [x] Compile follows templates/adventure/SKELETON.md document order.
- [x] QUALITY.md scores 110/120; Coherence (prep) passed with logic summary; Grounding audit passed (35/35).
- [x] No inactive setting material is active; no setting module is in play.
- [x] Notation is filled and followed.
- [x] Prepared stats/rules cite active authority; the previously open items (old-powder detonation, Lilly's 9mm row) are both closed — Option A ruled as RUL-2026-09-21-01, and the Glock (9mm) row pinned on her canonical sheet.
- [x] Mechanics sit beside the situation where they are used, once, in SP4/SP5.
- [x] Every situation with speakers has quoted lines in that situation; every secret has a GM Note.
- [x] Essential information has independent vectors (see Optional GM lookups, "The four graft vectors," and each SP's Essential information and vectors field).
- [x] Failures change time, position, danger, or relationship; none stop the main plot by itself.
- [x] Early removal has mitigation and re-entry handling (PC spotlight and safety).
- [x] First 15 minutes is an index checklist with live trouble and no speech/stats.
- [x] Current situation is phased (Phase A table start / Phase B after the jump) rather than describing the jump as already-happened at minute zero.
- [x] Climax situation is an index; speech and stats live in SP5 (and the fence-line pointer in SP4).
- [x] One home per payload inside this file — crew stats and yard illumination/cover tables live once, in SP5; SP4 points at them rather than repeating them.
- [x] Five-beat dashboard is not a visit order.
- [x] Climax combines opposition, environment, urgency, and objectives beyond winning the firefight.
- [x] Pacing dashboard includes a named 3–4 hour core.
- [x] End states provide a complete ending; the night-4 hook is named and not resolved here.
- [x] GM-only information is clearly marked (GM Note fields; GM secrets section).
- [x] No prepared event is written as though it occurred; this remains prep, not session history.
- [x] No Handouts index — none are prepared for this night.

After play - do not treat as prep

Do not create a session recap now. After the session, record only actual events, unresolved recollection kept distinct from observed fact, the powder ruling actually used (and its entry in `rules/rulings.md`), Len's and Kevin's outcomes, how much of the crew was taken,

and what Lilly actually knows about Chief Whitley going into night 4. Promote only established events into canon in this campaign's world; retire contradicted prep rather than rewriting it as though it happened.